

No One Dies Alone Taupō marks its first year

A year after calling for its first volunteers, No One Dies Alone Taupō is showing the power of community at life's most vulnerable moment.



No One Dies Alone Taupō volunteers

No One Dies Alone (NODA) provides trained volunteers to sit with people nearing the end of life, ensuring they are not alone and offering support to their loved ones.

Rotorua Hospital became New Zealand's first public hospital to offer the service in 2022. The programme was approved for extension to Taupō Hospital in June 2025.

NODA Taupō coordinator Kate Macalister-Nixon says the community response exceeded all expectations when Health New Zealand Lakes sought volunteers through social media.

"It was an incredible response. The social media post was shared widely and there was so much positivity from the community. We originally planned for 15 volunteers and could easily have taken more."

After completing vetting and training, the service became operational at Taupō Hospital in October 2025. Volunteer numbers have since settled at 11, and interest in joining the programme remains strong.

The group has supported two companions to date, contributing 99 volunteer hours at their bedsides during their final days.

“What we have found is that we are not only supporting people who may be alone; we are also supporting families who are exhausted.” — Kate Macalister-Nixon

Hospital staff have warmly embraced the service. It has also expanded beyond Taupō Hospital and is now available to residents at Monte Vista and an Oceania aged residential care facility.

Founding volunteer Libby Atkinson was among the many people who responded as soon as recruitment opened. Supporting one of NODA Taupō's first companions had a profound effect on her.

“It was completely calm, peaceful and beautiful. I was so grateful to be part of that. It is a privilege.” — Libby Atkinson

Source: Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora